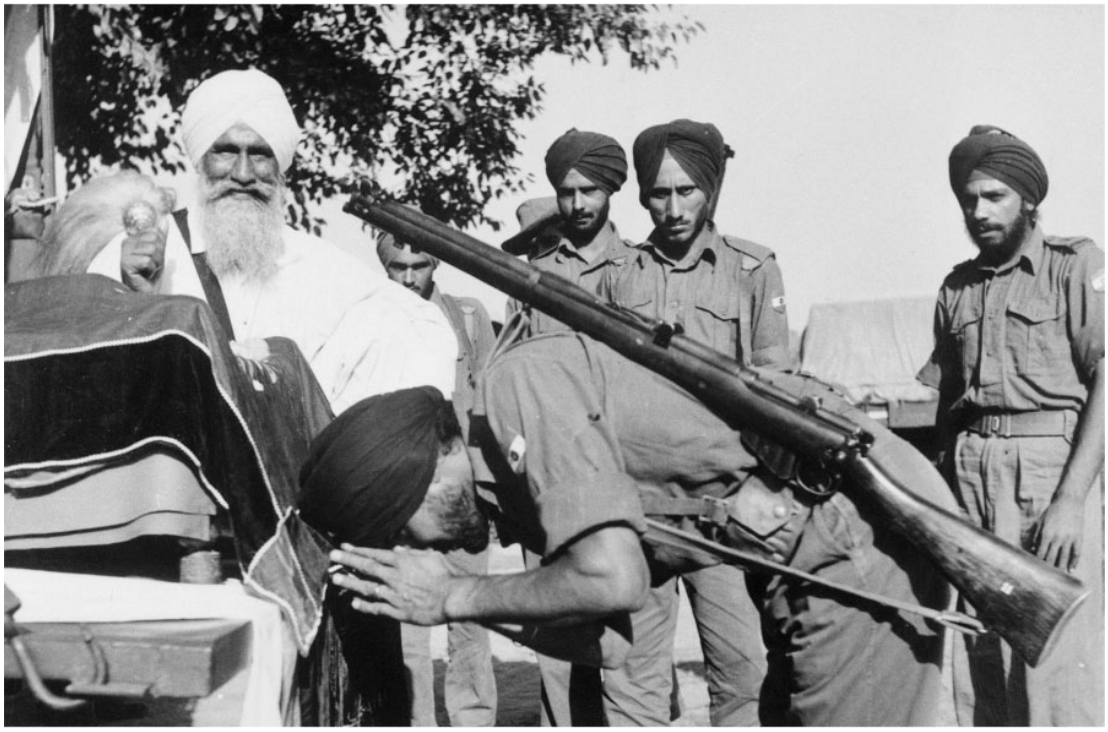


Sikh soldiers – rated among the fiercest fighters in the world – take part in a religious ceremony in a forward area on India's north-eastern frontier. The badge suggests they are members of XV Corps. The rifle-carrying Sikh in the foreground bows reverently before the *Guru Granth Sahib*, the Sikh scriptures, as his comrades look on. (Bettmann/Getty Images)

E: 1971 (1)

E1: Infantry captain, eastern sector

This young captain serving in Eastern Command (**1a**) wears the standard olive-green uniform and the Mk III helmet and has only the web belt with attachment braces (without pouches). He is carrying a Sterling SMG with bayonet fixed and butt extended, slung from his left shoulder. 'Leading from the front' is one of the military virtues that often decides the fate of a battle and the Indian Army strives to instil it in its officers. Many a battle has been won in the face of adversity, primarily because of an inspiring leader who carried the day by being the first to move and saying, 'Follow me.' The Indian Army's high officer-to-soldier casualty ratio well illustrates the fact that this trait is ingrained in its officers. During the 1971 conflict this ratio was 1:20, while it was 1:18 during the 1965 war and it went up to 1:17 during the Kargil War.

E2: Soldier, 2 PARA, Poongli bridge, Bangladesh

This paratrooper wears the Denison smock, the distinctive parachutist's helmet and standard web gear. He is armed with a Sterling SMG. On 11 December 1971, 2 PARA carried out a parachute drop about 8km north-east of Tangail, astride a track from Jamalpur and Mymensingh, across a ferry on the Lohajung River. Accompanied by a parachute field battery, an engineer platoon and signal and medical detachments, 2 PARA thereafter linked up with 1 MARATHA LI, the lead battalion of the advancing 95 Mountain Brigade coming